asked New Delhi if it would be interested in taking charge of a PRT. Involving both developmental and security management of a designated geographical area, a PRT would allow India to considerably expand its political presence in Afghanistan. With its GDP growth rates soaring at 8.5 per cent (2003–04) and 7.5 per cent (2004–05), finances were not a problem, but a PRT in Afghanistan risked India being bracketed as an 'occupying' force.[36] From the US perspective, an Indian PRT in Afghanistan had multiple benefits. Firstly, it would have filled a resource void that had been created by the Iraq invasion. Secondly, it would reduce pressure on the ISAF and NATO to provide security to Indian workers. The partisans in India had been blaming Washington's reluctance to allow Indian 'boots on the ground' for the deaths of Indian workers in Afghanistan (a misplaced blame given India's own reluctance to send troops). Soon after the killing of Kutty in November 2005, for instance, US diplomat in New Delhi, Richard O. Blake, took the opportunity to push for an Indian PRT in west Afghanistan in Washington.

Though the ultimate decision lay with India, Blake highlighted that an Indian PRT would be a first from the developing world (and would join South Korea and Australia as the third non-NATO PRT), would benefit from India's long-standing experience in development and peacekeeping, buttress Afghanistan's fledgling democracy, embed India in Afghanistan's reconstruction, and deepen US-India relations.[37] Additionally, routing Indian assistance via US channels would give the latter a better handle (if not control) over Indian actions in Afghanistan, and use the 'India card' with Pakistan effectively and at will. Blake had argued with his bosses in the US that an Indian PRT in west Afghanistan, far from the Pakistan border, would not raise objections from Islamabad (it was a naïve hope at best). By 2005 India was being proactively pushed to take charge of the PRT in west Afghanistan and get involved in counter-terrorism operations like other US allies.[38] Narayanan confirms that 'a lot of offers were made [by the US]. Holbrooke spent many hours discussing with me and asking us to send people [to Afghanistan] to help out. Not exactly boots on the ground. But we were very clear that we don't want to go beyond anything than the area of development. That's how our mind was working at that time.'[39] Having witnessed